

footwear designed by Ashish Soni, Rina Dhaka and Pratap, believes the potential for Indian designer footwear is tremendous. "Gone are the days when designers could just borrow shoes from any manufacturer for their shows. Today, discerning audiences call for better aesthetics," says Sethi, emphasising that there is a growing need for quality shoe-makers within the industry. Fashion designer Wendell Rodricks agrees: "The aesthetics that go into footwear designed for Indian clothes are vastly different from international sensibilities. A shoe can become a work of art and footwear lovers will pay any price to get something exclusive."

While Rina Shah of Rinaldi gave India one of its first accessory brands, designer Edwin Pinto was also making waves in distant Goa, albeit smaller ones, with his distinctly fresh look



HEMANT CHAWLA

DEEPIKA MEHRA Her label Vanilla Moon has a range of fashionable footwear both for the international and domestic market. Prices: Rs 1,990 onwards.

European designs to Indian markets, he doesn't fear any direct competition from international brands. "Price points are different because Indian brands are more affordable," he adds.

While retail outlets are buzzing with an onslaught of desi footwear fashion, the ramp is not bereft of shoe and awe. While Choo stilettos walked the fashion week ramp for Falguni & Shane Peacock and Aigner accessories accompanied Ranna Gill's Cuba-inspired runway, Mumbai-based Payal Kothari's brand Veruschka shod the feet of models at Manish Malhotra's grand finale. "In comparison to clothes and handbags, shoe construction is very complicated as you are working with limited space and a detail-intensive product," says Kothari.

For Delhi girl Swati Mehrotra too, fashion begins at the feet. "When I was young my father used to ask me to brush my shoes and tell me that your personality is judged by your shoes," she recalls. Today, the age-old wisdom has transformed into a funky fashion label Swati Modo. Filling a gap for a lack of "technically sound footwear designers", Mehrotra customises shoes on the basis of stories and themes, even technically altering footwear for people with foot problems.

The entry of international brands is more an impetus than a worry for these brands. The question then is: what will the Indian consumer opt for when faced with a choice between a Gucci pair worth Rs 30,000 and handmade Indian designer pumps selling for Rs 2,000? Says Kothari, "The average consumer may not hanker for international brands but he will definitely consider buying Indian designer footwear which costs much less." While Higgins believes that the time is just right for India-centric designer shoe couture, Rodricks too is optimistic, "The artisans and skills are all here. These just need to be honed to perfection." So what if the soles are from Argentina, the expertise is Italian and the hardware is from Europe—the sensibility is definitely Indian. *Phir bhi heel hai Hindustani*, did you say? ■



RAVI'S SHARMA

at footwear. Having designed shoes for couturier Rodricks's shows, Pinto today caters to the "unconventional" buyer. "People today are more open to experimenting and there is a demand for atypical designs," he says. Pinto believes that his unique footwear faces no competition from international brands. Others, however, like Deepika Mehra of Vanilla Moon and Birendra Higgins of b.higgins aim to meet global standards. Mehra's Delhi-based brand had been selling in parts of Europe before making its Indian foray. "Initially, Vanilla Moon was perceived as an

SWATI MEHROTRA Conceptual and creative, her range of footwear is customised and quirky. Prices: Rs 1,200 onwards.

expensive brand. But now in comparison with international brands, we offer great quality at lower prices," she says.

Another designer inspired by European standards is Mumbai-based Higgins, who thinks that style starts in Italy and ends in France. "Women in India have lots of options in footwear, whereas for men the choice is limited," he says. While Higgins brings the sleeker, tapered and flat lines of